

My first draft (to discuss some picks)

It's still early, but it's an opportunity to debate some players



FILIP NOVÁK

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Alright.

I was going to continue with the newly promoted teams series, but it's 40 degrees Celsius outside, so I decided it's time for a leaner, more fun (sorry, Coventry) good-vibes read you can take to the beach.

I'll discuss different approaches to building a Gameweek 1 squad in the coming weeks, so let's keep this one super simple:

- 1 I'm considering an 8-GW window with a heavier emphasis on the opening 6
- 2 No chip plans for that period, apart from wildcarding around GWs 6-8. There's an international break after Gameweek 5, and I'd ideally like to see a few GWs of info after that – **so this is just a raw draft with an emphasis on picks themselves**

The process behind the draft can be summed up as:

- pick “essentials” first
- add one MID I'm bullish on...
- complete the defence and make sure not to overspend
- pick the 3 remaining midfield players (the biggest challenge)

Let's do it.

Goalkeepers

Antonín Kinský: The way I see it, it's either betting on Arsenal's defence being elite again and going for a double-up that includes David Raya (£6.0m), or picking someone from the £4.5 million category to chase value.

It's the lowest-EV position, and I don't want to analyse small edges and tiny xP differences for keepers priced at £5.0 and £5.5 million.

I'm okay with Senne Lammens when, for example, you can't fit United DEF because you're bullish on other players. But that's it.

Current market projections on Solio look like this:

Name	Price	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	Average 
Raya 	6.0	4.62	3.67	3.59	4.12	3.64	4.15	3.94	4.21	3.99
A.Becker 	5.5	3.11	3.90	3.84	3.84	3.43	3.09	3.40	3.62	3.53
Donnarumma 	5.5	3.49	3.56	3.88	3.07	3.92	2.84	3.91	3.21	3.48
Sánchez 	5.0	3.22	3.55	2.91	4.09	3.29	3.61	3.61	3.45	3.47
Lammens 	5.0	3.98	3.73	3.44	2.79	3.29	3.24	3.32	3.40	3.40
Pope 	5.0	2.88	3.01	3.43	3.36	3.93	3.54	3.32	3.40	3.36
Kelleher 	5.0	3.23	3.39	3.87	3.24	3.02	3.12	2.99	3.82	3.34
Pickford 	5.5	3.55	3.21	3.22	3.00	3.88	3.77	3.04	2.68	3.29
Martinez 	5.0	3.02	3.04	3.84	3.76	3.11	3.50	3.13	2.92	3.29
Perri 	4.5	3.26	3.40	3.12	3.34	3.68	2.68	3.21	3.56	3.28
Sels 	5.0	3.51	2.67	3.26	3.04	3.81	3.38	2.94	3.51	3.26
Leno 	4.5	2.85	3.41	3.53	2.49	3.04	3.41	3.86	3.41	3.25
Roefs 	5.0	3.49	3.61	3.12	2.91	2.51	3.38	3.17	3.63	3.23
Kinsky 	4.5	2.82	3.25	3.29	3.65	3.28	2.88	3.70	2.64	3.19
Henderson 	5.0	3.05	2.65	3.14	3.68	3.21	3.49	2.94	3.18	3.17
Verbruggen 	4.5	3.13	2.63	3.55	3.48	2.86	3.47	3.61	2.57	3.16
Petrović 	4.5	2.31	3.50	2.83	3.19	2.72	2.49	3.61	2.75	2.93

That's what I mean by small edges.

? So, the question is: **Antonín Kinský or Bart Verbruggen?**

Towards the end of last season, both Spurs and Brighton performed great defensively.

Following De Zerbi's arrival, Spurs averaged the lowest xG conceded in the league across those 700 minutes (0.79 p90, per StatsBomb data via [FantasyFootballScout.com](https://fantasyfootballscout.com)). I mean, they won't be the best defence next season, but they should be solid, and the fixtures look good.

You might still remember I was raving about Brighton's defence in the second half of last season – since Gameweek 19, only Arsenal performed better in xGC, and they had the **5th-lowest xG per shot**

conceded, which is great for saves, especially for an amazing shot-stopper like Verbruggen.

But I'm picking Kinsky because I'd like to own a specific Brighton defender and to spread the risk. More on that later...

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Essentials

I don't want to use that horrid E-word too often, but I'm making an exception this time.

Cristian Mosquera (£5.5m): Losing William Saliba will affect the defence to some extent, but it's impossible to quantify the exact impact because the context changes and you can't draw a direct comparison with the previous season.

I believe Arsenal's defence will continue to rank among the best in the league, and given that run of fixtures, paying £5.5 million for a piece of that is a no-brainer.

When Saliba's back, you'll have enough information to solve that problem sensibly.

💡 Last season, Arsenal conceded about 0.75 xG and actual goals per 90, despite some injury problems. Solio has it by default at 0.92 goals conceded, which seems about right.

Still, they are comfortably at the top of the defensive table.

Check below:

Team	GW2	GW3	GW4	GW5	GW6	GW7	GW8	Total
Arsenal	34% AVL (A)	35% CHE (H)	45% SUN (A)	34% BHA (A)	47% LEE (H)	40% NFO (A)	49% EVE (H)	3.43
Man City	34% CRY (A)	45% COV (H)	21% MUN (A)	45% SUN (H)	19% LIV (A)	45% IPS (H)	27% AVL (A)	2.69
Man Utd	39% IPS (H)	29% EVE (A)	18% MCI (H)	27% FUL (A)	28% TOT (H)	27% LEE (A)	29% BOU (H)	2.40
Liverpool	37% NFO (H)	35% IPS (A)	37% FUL (H)	25% BOU (A)	20% MCI (H)	26% BRE (A)	31% BHA (H)	2.33
Chelsea	29% BHA (H)	16% ARS (A)	45% HUL (H)	25% BRE (A)	30% BOU (H)	30% EVE (A)	29% TOT (H)	2.28
Newcastle	18% TOT (A)	26% BOU (H)	24% LEE (A)	41% HUL (H)	29% COV (A)	25% AVL (H)	25% CRY (A)	2.03
Spurs	28% NEW (H)	26% NFO (A)	35% EVE (H)	27% AVL (H)	15% MUN (A)	38% COV (H)	15% CHE (A)	2.03
Nott'm Forest	12% LIV (A)	25% TOT (H)	19% AVL (A)	37% COV (H)	26% CRY (A)	18% ARS (H)	30% IPS (A)	1.97
Everton	20% BOU (A)	20% MUN (H)	19% TOT (A)	37% IPS (H)	35% HUL (A)	20% CHE (H)	13% ARS (A)	1.97
Aston Villa	20% ARS (H)	36% HUL (A)	34% NFO (H)	20% TOT (A)	30% BRE (H)	21% NEW (A)	17% MCI (H)	1.96
Brighton	14% CHE (A)	32% LEE (H)	30% COV (A)	19% ARS (H)	30% SUN (A)	33% CRY (H)	12% LIV (A)	1.94

Erling Haaland (£15.5m) & Bruno Fernandes (£12.0m):

As I've discussed in my article [on pricing and value](#), this season's pricing can be summarised in 3 points:

- make the previous campaign's top performers more expensive relative to the field
- increase prices for top DEFCON performers
- keep the rest of the players affordable

Owning both Haaland and Bruno doesn't compromise squad-building in my opinion, and you're getting two reliable captaincy options to shield all gameweeks.

Also, you cover their EO, as they are now selected in 75% and 49% of teams, respectively.

Player	£	TSB	Form	TP
 Haaland Man City FWD	15.5	75.2%	0.0	239
 João Pedro Chelsea FWD	7.5	54.1%	0.0	177
 B.Fernandes Man Utd MID	12.0	48.8%	0.0	235
 Szoboszlai Liverpool MID	7.0	48.2%	0.0	160
 Rogers Chelsea MID	7.5	32.4%	0.0	169
 Raya Arsenal GKP	6.0	30.4%	0.0	162
 Gabriel Arsenal DEF	8.0	25.5%	0.0	209
 Dubravka Spurs GKP	4.0	24.9%	0.0	96
 Guéhi Man City DEF	6.0	24.3%	0.0	179
 Shaw Man Utd DEF	4.5	24.0%	0.0	113

Now the one that might not be everyone's cup of tea.

Morgan Rogers & João Pedro (both £7.5m)

So far, it seems it's a hill I'm willing to die on.

I love Chelsea's squad, rate Xabi Alonso highly, and Rogers is reportedly a player the Spaniard demanded, which should make his xMins excellent. He'll also play in his best role – and that role always boosts his goal threat.

I know it's a new club for Rogers – and that club has a new coach – but it's not as if he's coming from the Bundesliga or the Eredivisie and needs to adapt. We have an 8,000-minute sample of him in the Premier League...

As for Pedro, I like the value, and I can sense the two developing good chemistry.

Morgan Rogers and Alejandro Garnacho could



be great picks if...

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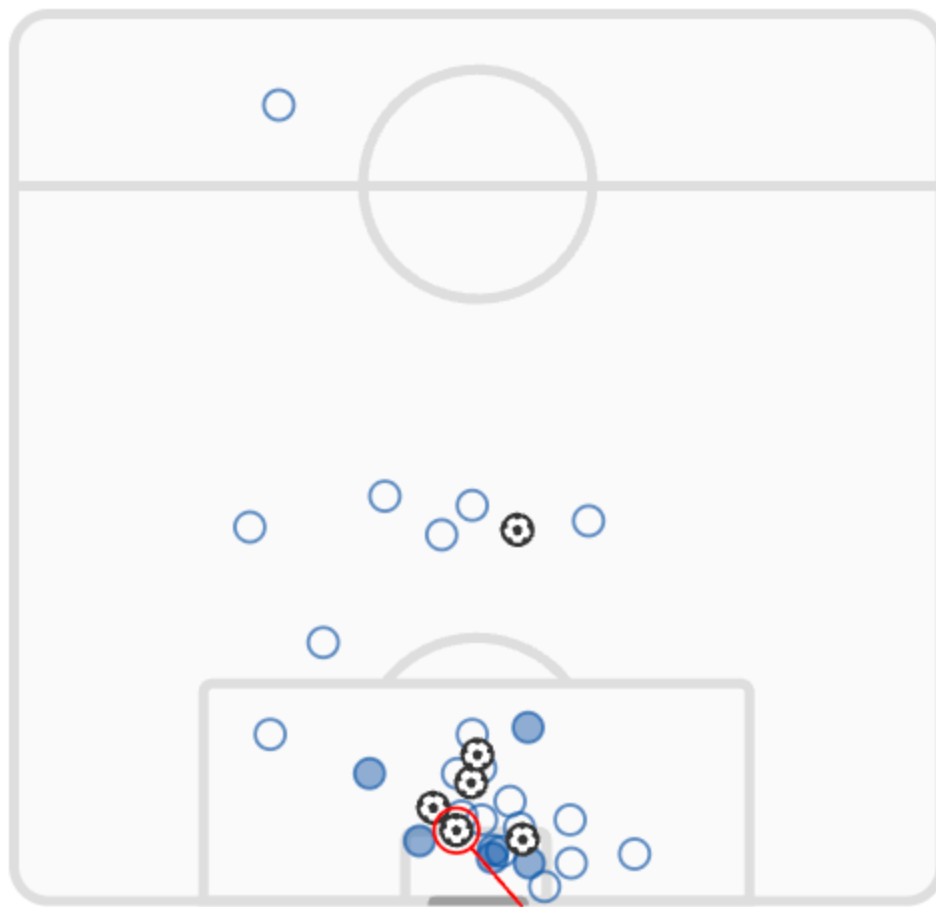
The defence

Alright, we already have **Cristian Mosquera** (£5.5m) in, so let's fill the remaining spots.

One of them is reserved for a probable DEFCON monster: **I really like Luka Vuškovič, Jaydee Canvot, and Tarik Muharemovič**, but as you might have guessed, no Verbruggen means I'm siding with **Luka Vuškovič** (£5.0m) for now.

However, I'll only start the season with him if I'm convinced he'll slot straight into the starting eleven. There's one more reason to include him, and you'll find it later in the midfield section.

Actually, two more reasons. Or should I say *sechs*?



32
Shots

6
Goals

4.39
xG

Vušković's shot map from the last Bundesliga season
(source: fotmob.com)

When I discussed those defensive numbers in the second half of the previous season, I should add that Manchester United were ranked 3rd, almost on a par with Brighton in xG conceded, and had the best xG per shot conceded during that period.

With Michael Carrick at the helm, **Harry Maguire** (£5.0m):

- averaged 8.80 defensive contributions per 90

- had a 47% DEFCON hit rate
- and was the most frequent set-piece target, racking up 9 attempts

Nice link-up with Bruno, so he's in.

Neco Williams (£5.0m) takes the 4th spot. Under Oliver Glasner, he's been promoted from full-back to wing-back, so there's potentially a strong combination of attacking threat and DEFCONs, along with favourable fixtures and a reasonable price tag.

£4 million DEF included

To improve the team's structure, I like the idea of having one £4.0m defender and a £4.5m forward.

All defenders from Coventry, Ipswich, and Hull were priced at the floor, so you'll always have a regular starter on the bench when needed. It's not rocket science – you check xMins and DEFCON potential.

For me, it's either Coventry or Ipswich, namely Bobby Thomas, Liam Kitching, Dara O'Shea, Issa Diop. Alternatively, Milan van Ewijk (though I'd rather go for defensive volume and goal threat than for chance creation).

I went with **Bobby Thomas** because he rotates well within the team.

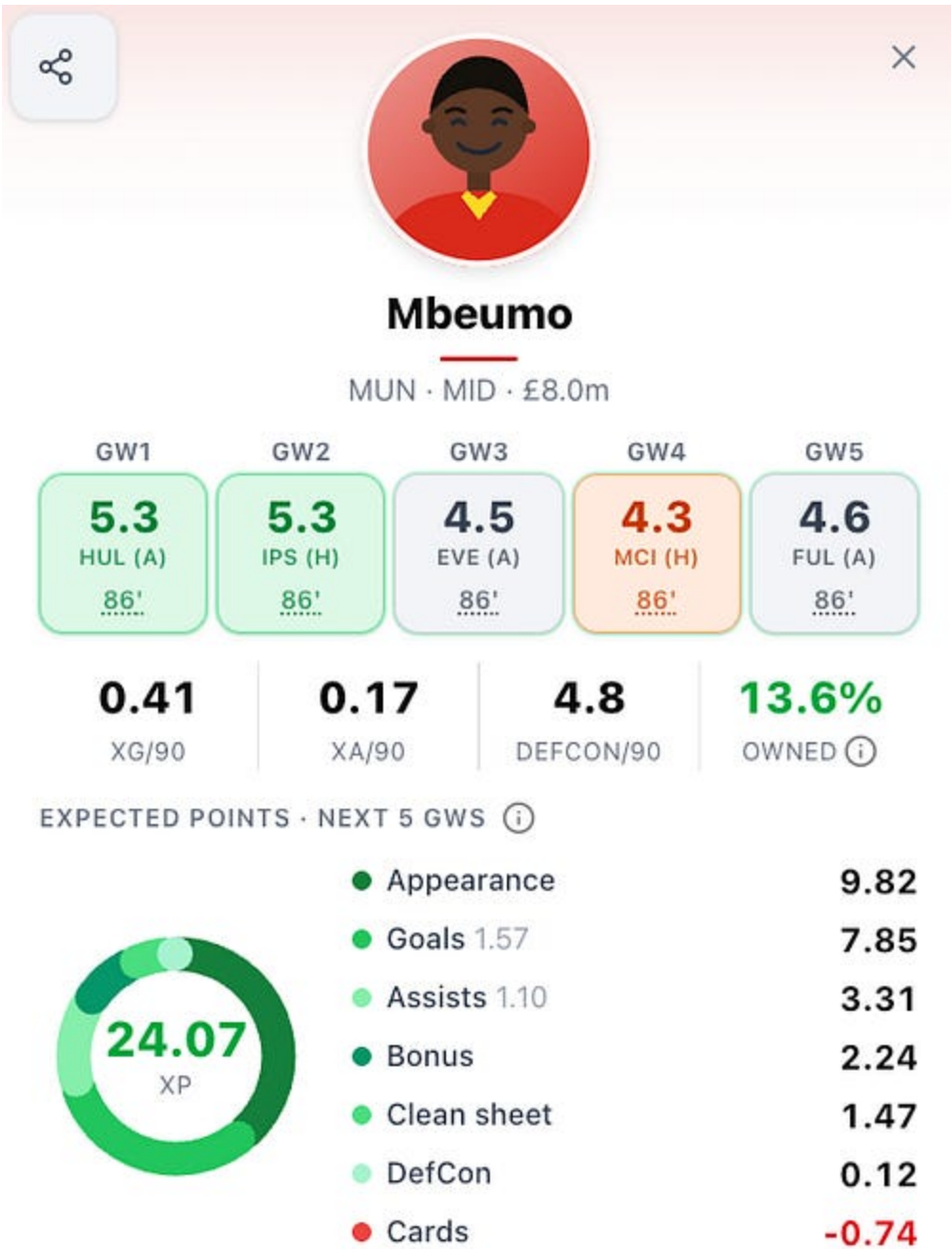
The midfield question: How to fill the 3 remaining spots?

Firstly, I'm completing Manchester United's triple up with **Bryan Mbeumo** (£8.0m), a player with whom Bruno formed one of the league's most dangerous attacking partnerships, generating 3.20 expected assists directly for him.

That might not seem like a lot, but it's a massive number.

Mbeumo's also a second set-piece taker, so there's a triple synergy between Bruno, Mbeumo and Maguire, which is what I want for those opening fixtures. It's on the aggressive side, but I don't mind that.

There are plenty of routes to points, as the Copilot model shows:



Ismaila Sarr (£6.5m) is sometimes frustrating, but he's firmly in the "value pick" category, as I like the combination of attacking threat and low price. Pierre Sage's system should suit him, and the fixtures are fine.

Pascal Gross (£5.5m) completes the team for yet another set-piece synergy – the main taker and, presumably, the biggest aerial threat in Vušković.

So, this is the draft:

FTs / Available 15 / 15 ITB £ 0.0

PRICE NO CHIP

GW1

RESET ACTIONS

£4,5
→ KINSKY
BRE(A)

£5,0
→ VUSKOVIC
AVL(H)

£5,5
→ MOSQUERA
COV(H)

£5,0
→ MAGUIRE
HUL(A)

£5,0
→ N.WILLIAMS
LEE(H)

£12,0
→ B.FERNANDES (C)
HUL(A)

£6,5
→ SARR
EVE(A)

£8,0
→ MBEUMO
HUL(A)

£7,5
→ ROGERS
FUL(A)

£15,5
→ HAALAND
BOU(H)

£7,5
→ JOÃO PEDRO
FUL(A)

£4,0
→ DUBRAVKA
BRE(A)

£5,5
→ GROSS
AVL(H)

£4,0
→ THOMAS
ARS(A)

£4,5
→ WALLE EGELI
SUN(H)

Potential caveats, and changes

The obvious weakness of that draft, depending on how you interpret it, is the lack of Manchester City players (apart from Haaland) and no Liverpool coverage.

💡 You can replace Vuskovič with **Joško Gvardiol**, and Rogers/Mbeumo with **either Dominik Szoboszlai** or **Florian Wirtz** if you're bullish on those teams. At the moment, I'd still like to see more and would include them in the wildcard #1 if needed. But maybe there will be strong pre-season signals that will make me re-evaluate.

💡 If you only want Liverpool coverage, Florian Wirtz is too expensive for this team, but Dominik Szoboszlai is doable, provided you can find a £5.0m MID you like – I suspect it could be **Mamadou Sangaré** from Brentford, who hasn't been officially introduced yet, so let's see. Fingers crossed he's that cheap.

💡 **If you want to play a 3-FWD structure**, you can simply move the money from midfield to attack, upgrading Walle Egeli to Dominic Calvert-Lewin and nerfing the midfield. I prefer the original plan at the moment, but there's no problem with that alternative structure.

Note that the team selection is still wide open, as the summer transfer window will last until Gameweek 3, and incoming and departing players can significantly alter teams' dynamics. There could also be injuries, and we'll get information on players' xMins, roles, or managers' tactical plans. **Context is king.**

That's all for today.

Enjoy the weekend and see you soon!